

4 Techniques That Lift a Story

Quick reference: what each technique is, how it looks in practice, and how to try it yourself.

1 In Medias Res

Starting the story **in the middle of the action**, not at the calm beginning — the reader is dropped straight into a moment already in motion, and background details are filled in afterwards, not before.

Calm setup



Story starts here → action already happening



Explain how we got here

"The door slammed behind her before she'd even decided to run." — we don't yet know who she is or why she's running, but we're already inside the moment.

Try it: Cut your planned opening line. Start instead at the moment something is already happening — a shout, a slam, a hand grabbing an arm — and explain the "why" a sentence or two later.

2 Cyclical Structure

The ending **echoes or returns to** the opening — the same image, phrase, place, or object reappears, but it now means something different because of what the character has been through.

Opening image

... story happens ...

Same image returns, changed meaning

Story opens: "The key felt too heavy in her pocket." Story closes: "The key finally felt light." — same object, but it now carries the emotional change she's been through.

Try it: Pick one object, phrase, or image from your opening line. Plant it again in your final line, changed by what's happened — it signals a complete, planned structure rather than a story that just stops.

3 Show, Don't Tell

Instead of naming an emotion directly, show it through **action, dialogue, or physical detail** — let the reader work it out, which is more convincing and more sophisticated than a label.

"She was nervous."

becomes

Physical detail + action

Instead of "She was nervous," try: "Her hands wouldn't stay still, and she read the same sentence three times without taking in a word." — same emotion, shown rather than named.

Try it: Find any sentence with a feeling-word (nervous, angry, excited). Delete the word and replace it with what the character's body or actions would actually do in that moment.

4 Sentence Variety for Pace

Mixing **short, punchy sentences** with **longer, layered ones** to control pace — short sentences speed a scene up (tension, shock, action), long sentences slow it down (reflection, description, calm).

Short. Sharp. Fast.

vs

One long, flowing sentence that lingers, builds, and slows the reader down

"She ran. No time to look back. The door slammed." — then, once safe: "It was only now, catching her breath against the cold brick wall, that she let herself wonder what she'd actually seen."

Try it: In your most dramatic moment, break one long sentence into two or three short ones. In your calmest moment, do the opposite — combine short sentences into one longer, flowing one.